

Nourish & Share

IT Support & System Operations Guide

A practical support, operational readiness, troubleshooting, security, and handover guide.

Purpose of This Guide

This revised guide has been intentionally simplified from the earlier technical infrastructure documentation. It removes unnecessary internal implementation details, exact source-file references, credentials, API route descriptions, database schemas, test-account details, and other information that is not required for an IT Support role.

The focus is on what an IT Support team member needs to understand to support, test, troubleshoot, maintain, and help prepare the Nourish & Share system for operational use.

1. Project Overview

Nourish & Share is a web-based platform aligned with Sustainable Development Goal 2: Zero Hunger. Its purpose is to help connect organizations with surplus food to organizations that can receive and distribute that food, while supporting coordination around reservations, pickups, communication, and administration.

The system is organised into three main user-facing areas:

- Public Website — introduces the platform, its purpose, and the available entry points.
- Private Platform — provides separate experiences for Donors and Recipients.
- Admin Website — supports oversight and management of approved platform activities.

The main roles are:

- Donor — creates and manages available food donations and coordinates collection.
- Recipient — discovers available food, makes reservations, and coordinates pickup.
- Administrator — oversees relevant platform operations and user or organization management.

This document is an IT Support and System Operations guide. It is intentionally high-level and does not expose unnecessary source-code, database-schema, credential, API-route, or internal file details.

2. System Access and Operational Requirements

The project requires an appropriate local development environment and a modern web browser. Depending on the services enabled for a given environment, support personnel

may also require access to the project's application services and approved administrative accounts.

The project uses web technologies and supporting cloud services for application functionality. Before supporting or preparing the system for deployment, the IT Support team should confirm:

- Required runtime and package-management tools are available.
- Project dependencies have been installed where applicable.
- Required application services are accessible.
- Internet access is available for external services used by the platform.
- The supported browser environment is functioning correctly.
- Access to administrative or service accounts is controlled and provided only to authorised personnel.

Exact versions and commands should be taken from the project's approved configuration and setup instructions rather than copied into this document when they may change.

3. System Setup and Running the Application

IT Support should use the project's existing setup instructions and configuration to prepare the application. At a high level, the process is to:

1. Obtain an approved copy of the project.
2. Install the required dependencies.
3. Confirm that required local or cloud services are available.
4. Configure approved environment or service settings without exposing credentials.
5. Start the application using the project's supported development or hosting process.
6. Verify that the Public, Donor, Recipient, and Admin experiences can be reached as expected.

If a setup requirement is missing or unclear, it should be recorded as Requires Configuration or Requires Developer Clarification rather than guessed.

4. External Services and Configuration

The current project integrates with application and cloud services for areas such as authentication, data storage, server-side functionality, image handling, mapping or location features, and communication or notification features where configured.

IT Support responsibilities include confirming that:

- Required services are available.
- Service configuration is appropriate for the current environment.
- Secrets, passwords, tokens, and private credentials are not exposed in documentation or shared unnecessarily.
- Production configuration is separated from local development configuration where required.
- Any service that is referenced but not fully configured is clearly tracked before deployment.

Cloudinary is relevant to the project where image upload functionality is enabled. Support personnel should verify that image uploads succeed and that returned image references are available to the application. Actual service credentials must not be included in this document.

5. User Access and Role Support

Nourish & Share uses role-based experiences. IT Support should understand the difference between normal access problems and role-based restrictions.

Typical access areas include:

- Public users — access public information and entry points.
- Donors — access donor-specific donation and coordination features.
- Recipients — access recipient-specific food discovery, reservation, and coordination features.
- Administrators — access approved administrative and oversight functions.

When investigating an access issue, support should first confirm the user's identity, account state, assigned role, and the area they are attempting to access. Users should not be given permissions outside their authorised role simply to bypass an issue.

6. Operational Support Areas

The main support areas include:

- Application availability and browser access.
- User sign-in and authorised access.
- Role-based navigation.
- Food donation and reservation workflows.
- Pickup coordination.
- Profile and image-upload functionality.
- Chat or communication features where enabled.
- Administrative access and platform oversight features.
- Connected service availability.

Support should focus on identifying whether an issue is caused by the user's environment, account access, application configuration, an external service, or the application itself before escalation.

7. Common Issues and Basic Troubleshooting

A practical support process should follow these steps:

1. Record the issue and affected user or system area.
2. Confirm whether the issue affects one user or multiple users.
3. Check browser, network, and basic device conditions.
4. Confirm the user is signed in with the correct account and role.
5. Check whether the relevant application area or connected service is available.

6. Reproduce the issue where appropriate without exposing private user data.
7. Escalate application-code, database, security-rule, or service-configuration issues to the responsible technical team.

Examples of issues that may require support include:

- The website or dashboard does not load.
- A user cannot sign in or reach the correct role-based area.
- A profile image or food image does not upload.
- A donation or reservation does not appear as expected.
- A pickup status is unclear or does not update.
- A communication feature is unavailable.
- An administrator cannot access an authorised management function.

The troubleshooting record should describe the symptom, affected area, checks performed, and escalation outcome. It should not include passwords, tokens, or unnecessary personal information.

8. Security and Safe Handling of Access

IT Support must protect access to the platform and its supporting services.

Key practices include:

- Never place passwords, private keys, tokens, or secret credentials in documentation, screenshots, or public repositories.
- Use approved methods for storing and sharing sensitive configuration.
- Confirm that users only receive access appropriate to their role.
- Protect administrative accounts and review unexpected access attempts.
- Report suspected security issues to the responsible project or development team.
- Avoid making direct production changes without appropriate approval and verification.

The application should rely on backend or service-level access controls rather than treating hidden interface elements as security protection.

9. Backup, Recovery, and Maintenance Considerations

Before a production launch, the team should define and verify backup and recovery procedures for important application data and configuration.

Areas to consider include:

- Application data.
- Uploaded media references and associated service configuration.
- Production environment configuration.
- Deployment settings.
- Administrative access recovery.

If a formal backup or recovery process is not yet configured, this should be recorded as Requires Configuration before production deployment. This document does not assume that a complete production backup process already exists.

10. Deployment Readiness and Maintenance

IT Support should help verify that the system is operationally ready before deployment. This includes:

- Confirming the application can start or be hosted using the approved process.
- Confirming required services are configured.
- Verifying production configuration without exposing credentials.
- Testing the Public Website.
- Testing authorised Donor access and key workflows.
- Testing authorised Recipient access and key workflows.
- Testing authorised Admin access and key workflows.
- Testing image upload functionality where enabled.
- Checking that major user journeys produce expected results.
- Recording known limitations, incomplete features, or configuration tasks.

The current project should be treated as the source of truth for deployment requirements. Hosting choices or infrastructure not already approved should not be presented as implemented.

11. Escalation and Support Boundaries

IT Support can perform first-level investigation, environment checks, access verification, service availability checks, deployment readiness checks, and operational troubleshooting.

Issues that require changes to application logic, database structure, security rules, or other development implementation should be escalated to the responsible developer or technical team. This helps avoid accidental changes to the system while still giving IT Support a clear and meaningful operational role.

12. IT Support Handover Checklist

Checklist Item	Status	Notes
Required software and approved tools are available	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Project setup process has been reviewed	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Dependencies or required packages are installed where applicable	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Required application services are accessible	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.

Sensitive credentials are stored and shared securely	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Public Website access has been tested	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Donor access and key workflows have been tested	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Recipient access and key workflows have been tested	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Admin access and authorised functions have been tested	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Image upload functionality has been tested where enabled	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Common support and escalation procedures are understood	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Known incomplete features or configuration tasks are recorded	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Backup and recovery requirements have been reviewed	Requires Configuration / Verification	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Production deployment requirements have been confirmed	Requires Configuration / Verification	Record outcome during handover or testing.
Security and role-based access checks have been completed	Verify	Record outcome during handover or testing.

Current Documentation Principle

This guide should remain aligned with the actual state of the Nourish & Share project. Where a feature or operational process is incomplete, it should be labelled clearly rather than described as finished. Sensitive information should be kept out of the document, and detailed developer-level architecture should remain in separate technical documentation when required.